excuse that law and order in Delhi is under the Centre's jurisdiction—one of AAP's pet peeves—no longer holds. The BJP rules at both the Centre and the capital, so Delhi Police now has a 'unified command'. Another old excuse, of jurisdiction gaps, also no longer applies.

Financial challenges: Delhi's financial picture does raises concerns. The revenue surplus (funds left after expenses) dropped from Rs 14,457

DELHI'S REVENUE SURPLUS SHRUNK TO ₹3,231 CR. IN FY25. THE NEW WELFARE SCHEMES RISK CREATING A SHORTFALL

crore in 2022-23 to an estimated Rs 3,231 crore in 2024-25. The expensive welfare schemes risk creating another revenue shortfall. Tax collections as a share of Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP) have shrunk in recent years. The new government will have to change the pattern, trim costs and seek fresh income sources.

Air quality crisis: Delhi's poor air quality has been a perennial problem. In January, the city's AQI hit the 450 range triggering Stage-III of the Graded Response Action Plan. The new regime must conceive an all-year-round action plan, so that pollution is mitigated in the winter months. This needs tough measures, like checking wanton construction, cracking down on polluting vehicles and increasing the city's green cover. The 2020 Delhi Electric Vehicles Policy required 25 per cent of new vehicles to be electric by 2024. That fallen ideal can do with a spark. ■

BRAHMOS

A Missile to Balance Out Beijing



By Pradip R. Sagar

Foreign policy often involves a delicate balance between strategic, security and commercial interests. For India, it entails stabilising its northern borders with China and keeping its trade ties with Beijing intact on the one hand, while supporting the cause of a secure Indian Ocean region and Indo-Pacific through its membership with the Quad group of nations and a shared vigil in Southeast Asia on the other. At the heart of this venture, delicate and purposive at once, is the BrahMos supersonic cruise missile. Jointly developed by India and Russia, this advanced weapon system is emerging as a key tool in India's defence export strategy—and a symbol of its growing engagement with a clutch of Southeast Asian nations bound together by their common sense of threat in the face of China's maritime muscle-flexing.

The Philippines acquired the BrahMos system in 2024. Now Indonesia is in talks with India to follow suit. If the deal is finalised, it will become the second Southeast Asian nation to equip itself with the



SHOW OF ARMS The BrahMos missile at the Republic Day Parade, 2025

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR